



Exciting talent: Shelton, beaten by Sinner in the second semifinal, is a work in progress. GETTY IMAGES

The 15,000 spectators in Rod Laver Arena cheered Zverev on to get back into the match, even though he looked resigned much of the time. When Sinner erred on a drop shot to make the score 5-6, 30-all in the second set, the crowd roared. But Sinner won the next two points to quash the threat and force a tiebreaker.

Serving at 4-all, Zverev suffered the unkindest cut of all when Sinner's forehand clipped the top of the net and barely plopped over for a fluke net cord winner. On the next point, Zverev missed a backhand serve return and swiped his racket on the court in frustration. Sinner wrapped up the 7-4 tiebreaker with his trademark 1-2 punch — a wide serve followed by a forehand winner into the open court. Zverev smashed his racket during the changeover.

Zverev, like the fans, sensed there would be no miracle comeback for him, as there had been a year ago

for Sinner against Daniil Medvedev. Sinner is a far better player now in every way. He has become a harder-hitting version of Djokovic, albeit slightly less athletic.

As Mark Petchey, the *Tennis Channel* analyst, said: "You feel like you hit an offensive shot to Sinner's backhand corner, and it comes back with interest on it." His mastery of the extreme open-stance two-hander — almost doing the splits while maintaining perfect balance — looks exactly like that of the hyper-flexible Djokovic.

Zverev failed to ignite the crowd with any positive body language, which, in turn, would have raised his energy level. An occasional chant of "Let's go, Sascha!" wasn't enough to lift his spirits or game in the third set. Sinner got the only service break he needed for 4-2. On championship point, Sinner showcased his versatility with a forehand drop shot followed by a backhand passing winner.

A shock exit for the GOAT

A final pitting Sinner against either Alcaraz, who captured the French Open and Wimbledon last

year, or Djokovic would have been more entertaining and likely much closer. Unfortunately, seedings based solely on the flawed ATP rankings caused No. 7 Djokovic to face No. 3 Alcaraz prematurely in the quarterfinals. Djokovic prevailed 4-6, 6-4, 6-3, 6-4, but it was a Pyrrhic victory as he tore his left hamstring muscle.

For the first time in their eight matches, the crowd pulled for the ageing (fading?) champion. Chants of "Nole! Nole!" reverberated around the stadium well past midnight. The exasperated Alcaraz did himself no favours when he mimicked the injured Djokovic with fake hobbling.

"Pretty much a normal Djokovic match, drama incorporated," said *ESPN* analyst Patrick McEnroe. "It felt like it was the final of a Slam. I wish it was," said *Tennis Channel's* Lindsay Davenport.

The sterling performance evoked memories of Djokovic's greatest career matches, prompting all-time great Martina Navratilova to comment, "Novak had great depth and precision. It's like he had the ball on a string. I've never seen Alcaraz